

Assemblage

The word 'assemblage' was first applied by Dubuffet in the early 1950s to a series of collages of butterfly wings that he called *Assemblages d'Empreintes*. However, the earliest examples of this kind of artwork are probably Synthetic Cubist works by Picasso and Braque, or Duchamp's readymades. Since then, assemblages, comprising usually banal, natural or manufactured materials, objects or fragments of things that were not originally intended as art materials, have become a fairly regular form of art. Some artists have created these three-dimensional collages almost exclusively, others as a small part of an overall body of work. A 1961 New York exhibition 'The Art of Assemblage' showcased the work of nearly 140 artists, including Braque, Dubuffet, Duchamp, Picasso, Schwitters, Man Ray (1890–1976), Joseph Cornell (1903–72), Robert Rauschenberg (1925–2008) and George Herms (b.1935). The diversity of materials, styles and ideas on display was vast. Cornell, for instance, became known for his boxed assemblages created from found objects that combine elements of Constructivism with Surrealistic fantasies.



Cornell, *Penny Arcade*, c.1962